

— EDITION 10

From Cowrie Shells to Agentic Wallets

Human history is just a series of upgrades to how we store and pass value. We are about to witness Phase 5.

A 7-part breakdown

SWIPE >>>>

0101 / 07

10,000 Years of Ledger Upgrades.

Money evolves whenever the underlying architecture of human trust scales. We are on the precipice of moving value from human networks to software networks.

0202 / 07

| Phase 1: Physical Cash & Coins.

Tangible, physical trust. Limited by geography, physical space, and the immediate proximity of the transacting parties.

0303 / 07

Phase 2: Plastic Credit & Card Rails.

Centralized network trust. Built for a world of telephone lines, paper signatures, and trusted institutional clearing houses like Visa and Mastercard.

0404 / 07

Phase 3: Mobile Wallets & Biometric Pay.

Frictionless biometric trust. Apple Pay and Google Wallet condensed financial credentials into secure, localized smartphone hardware tokens.

0505 / 07

Phase 4: Embedded Finance.

Contextual, invisible trust. Financial services dissolved straight into corporate software platforms like Shopify, Uber, and Airbnb.

0606 / 07

Phase 5: Agentic Commerce.

Autonomous, programmatic trust. Value is managed, negotiated, and settled directly by autonomous machine agents operating on behalf of human principals.

0707 / 07

Save This: The 5 Phases of Money.

1) Physical cash — proximity trust. 2) Card rails — institutional trust. 3) Mobile wallets — biometric trust. 4) Embedded finance — contextual trust. 5) Agentic commerce — *programmatic trust*. Each phase scaled trust further; this one removes the human from the loop.

— THE TAKEAWAY

Ready for Phase **5?**

Comment which phase shift created the most value. Repost to share the map, and follow for daily agentic payments breakdowns.

◆ Joseph Bankole